

The Second Table in Gerar

Abraham breaks the second table of the law in eighteen verses — and a pagan king keeps it better. Five sessions in Genesis 20, anchored in Hebrews.

SESSIONS 5 · 45–60 min TEXT Genesis 20 (ESV) STANDARDS WSC · WLC · Heidelberg

How to run it

One commandment per week. Read all eighteen verses of Genesis 20 aloud at the start of every session — it is short, and the point of the study is that a single episode carries all five commandments at once.

	COMMANDMENT	GENESIS 20	HEBREWS
VI	You shall not murder	3, 7, 11, 18	2:14–15 · 13:6
VII	You shall not commit adultery	2–6, 16	13:4
VIII	You shall not steal	2, 7, 14–16	13:5 · 10:34
IX	You shall not bear false witness	2, 5, 9–13	6:18–19 · 4:12–13
X	You shall not covet	2, 11, 13	11:13, 16 · 13:5

Numbering follows the Reformed order used by Westminster and Heidelberg — sixth murder, seventh adultery, eighth theft, ninth false witness, tenth coveting. Lutheran and Roman numbering splits coveting in two and joins the first and second; if someone in the group grew up with that order, name the difference at the outset rather than mid-study.

OPENING FRAME — BEFORE SESSION ONE

Two tables, four rules, three uses

THE TWO TABLES

The Ten Words divide. The first four govern love of God; the last six govern love of neighbor. Jesus makes the division explicit in Matthew 22:37–40, and Paul gathers the second table into one sentence: “*Love does no wrong to*

a neighbor; therefore love is the fulfilling of the law” (Romans 13:9–10). Commandments six through ten are the second table — the load-bearing wall between a person and everyone else.

FOUR RULES FOR READING THEM

The Larger Catechism gives rules for understanding the commandments. Four of them govern this study.

- **The law is spiritual.** It binds the understanding, will, and affections — not merely outward behavior.
- **A negative implies a positive.** Where a sin is forbidden, the contrary duty is commanded; where a duty is commanded, the contrary sin is forbidden.
- **One sin names its whole family.** Under one sin or duty, all of the same kind are included — with their causes, means, occasions, and appearances.
- **We are our neighbor’s keeper.** We are bound to do what we can that others keep the commandment too, according to our place.

WLC 99 — the rules for understanding the ten commandments. Rule three is why Genesis 20 is not five separate sins loosely stacked. It is one act of unbelief branching into five.

THE THREE USES OF THE LAW

First, civil — it restrains sin in society, believer and unbeliever alike. Watch for it in Abimelech. **Second, pedagogical** — a mirror that shows sin, kills self-confidence, and drives us to Christ. Watch for it in Abraham. **Third, didactic** — the rule of grateful obedience for the redeemed. This is why Heidelberg places the commandments in Part Three, *Gratitude*, after the sections on sin and deliverance rather than before. The law does not save us; it shows the saved how to live.

THE SETTING

Genesis 20 falls late. Abraham has already been justified by faith (Genesis 15:6; Romans 4:3). He has already received circumcision as the sign of the covenant (Genesis 17). He has just interceded for Sodom. Isaac is born one chapter later, in Genesis 21:1–2.

And here, in that late season, Abraham repeats verbatim the sin of Genesis 12:10–20. He is not a young man learning. He is a mature believer running an old, settled policy (20:13).

The question the whole study turns on: if the friend of God can do this after all that, what is the law actually for?

VI

SESSION ONE • THE SIXTH COMMANDMENT

You shall not murder

“You shall not murder.”

EXODUS 20:13 • DEUTERONOMY 5:17

IN GERAR

The chapter is soaked in death. God’s first word to Abimelech is a death sentence.

“Behold, you are a dead man because of the woman whom you have taken, for she is a man’s wife.”

GENESIS 20:3

The sentence extends to the whole household — “*you shall surely die, you and all who are yours*” (20:7). And a quieter death runs underneath it: “*the LORD had closed all the wombs of the house of Abimelech*” (20:18). A kingdom with no future.

Abraham’s own explanation is the hinge.

“I did it because I thought, There is no fear of God at all in this place, and they will kill me because of my wife.”

GENESIS 20:11

Notice what he does with that fear. He does not flee, pray, or tell the truth and trust God with the outcome. He arranges for his wife to absorb the danger instead of him. He preserves his own life by spending hers.

THE REFORMED LENS

The sixth commandment *requires* “all lawful endeavours to preserve our own life, and the life of others,” and forbids taking life unjustly “or whatsoever tendeth thereunto.” That last clause is the indictment. Abraham never lifts a hand, and he still stands on the wrong side of the sixth commandment, because he set in motion what tends toward another’s death.

WSC 68–69 · WLC 135–136 — the reach of the commandment extends to whatever *tends* to the taking away of life.

HC 105–107 — God forbids not only killing but envy, hatred, anger and the desire for revenge, and positively requires that I love my neighbor, be patient, and do good even to my enemies.

Note the reversal. Abraham assumes Gerar has no fear of God. Gerar turns out to be full of it: “*the men were very much afraid*” (20:8). His assessment of the pagans was itself a form of contempt — and contempt is where the sixth commandment starts.

THE HEBREWS ANCHOR

“Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery.”

HEBREWS 2:14–15

Fear of death is not a footnote in Genesis 20. It is the engine. Abraham is a believer in lifelong slavery to a fear Christ came to break. Set it beside Hebrews 13:6 — “*The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?*” — the sentence Abraham could not say in Gerar.

QUESTIONS

1. Abraham never touches a weapon. On what grounds does the sixth commandment still accuse him?
2. Where does self-preservation stop being a duty toward yourself and become a sin against a neighbor? WSC 68 requires both — how do you tell them apart?
3. Whose safety do you quietly assume will absorb the cost of your fear — a spouse, a child, an employee, a friend?
4. What would Abraham have had to believe about God at verse 11 in order to tell the truth at verse 2?

CONFESSION AND PRAYER

Confess fear of man as a form of unbelief, not merely a weakness. Pray Hebrews 13:6 back as a petition, not a slogan.

VII

SESSION TWO • THE SEVENTH COMMANDMENT

You shall not commit adultery

“You shall not commit adultery.”

EXODUS 20:14 • DEUTERONOMY 5:18

IN GERAR

“*And Abimelech king of Gerar sent and took Sarah*” (20:2). God’s objection is stated as a bare fact of created order — “*she is a man’s wife*” (20:3). Not *she is under a contract*: a bond God recognizes and defends whether or not the parties disclose it.

Then the sentence that reorganizes the whole chapter.

“Yes, I know that you have done this in the integrity of your heart, and it was I who kept you from sinning against me. Therefore I did not let you touch her.”

GENESIS 20:6

Sarah’s chastity is not preserved by her husband. It is not preserved by her own resourcefulness. It is preserved by God restraining a pagan king from a sin the king did not know he was committing.

THE REFORMED LENS

The seventh commandment requires “the preservation of our own and our neighbour’s chastity, in heart, speech, and behaviour.” Now apply rule four from the opening frame — we are bound to help others keep the commandment. Abraham was Sarah’s covenant head. His assigned work under the seventh commandment was to guard her. He organized her exposure instead, and God had to do the guarding.

WSC 71–72 • WLC 137–139 — chastity in heart, speech and behaviour, ours and our neighbour’s.

HC 108–109 — God condemns not only the act but everything that incites it, and calls body and soul together a temple of the Holy Spirit.

Restraining grace. Abimelech’s “integrity of heart and innocence of hands” (20:5) is real at the level of intent — and God says plainly it was *God’s* doing, not the king’s virtue. This is common grace: God restraining sin in people outside the covenant, here specifically to protect the line Isaac will come from. Abimelech’s clean hands are a gift, not an achievement. So are most of ours.

And Sarah is publicly vindicated (20:16) — a thousand pieces of silver, “a sign of your innocence in the eyes of all who are with you.” God does not leave the wronged party’s reputation in the wreckage of the wrong.

THE HEBREWS ANCHOR

“Let marriage be held in honor among all, and let the marriage bed be undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterous.”

HEBREWS 13:4

Read against 20:2–6, the irony lands hard. The one who held the marriage in *dishonor* was the husband. The pagan court had to be warned off by direct revelation. Hebrews says God will judge; Genesis 20 shows him doing it, in a dream, before dawn.

QUESTIONS

1. God calls Sarah “a man’s wife” before either man in the story treats her that way. What does that settle about who defines a marriage?
2. Verse 6 says God kept Abimelech from sinning. Where has God restrained you from a sin you were fully prepared to commit — and did you notice at the time?
3. WSC 71 requires preserving our *neighbour’s* chastity, not only our own. What does that duty look like concretely in your household, and in what you publish, share, and watch?
4. Abraham’s failure was not lust. It was refusing to spend himself to protect his wife. Is that a seventh-commandment sin? Argue it from WSC 71.

CONFESSION AND PRAYER

Thank God for restraints you never asked for. Confess the protective duties you have quietly outsourced — to God, or to no one.

VIII

SESSION THREE • THE EIGHTH COMMANDMENT

You shall not steal

“You shall not steal.”

EXODUS 20:15 • DEUTERONOMY 5:19

IN GERAR

The verb in verse 2 is *took*. What was taken was not livestock but a person — a wife lifted out of a marriage. God’s remedy is the language of returned property: “*return the man’s wife*” (20:7).

Then the restitution.

“Then Abimelech took sheep and oxen, and male servants and female servants, and gave them to Abraham, and returned Sarah his wife to him. And Abimelech said, ‘Behold, my land is before you; dwell where it pleases you.’”

GENESIS 20:14–15

This is far beyond what Exodus 22 would later require. The pagan king over-restores. And Abraham keeps it. He leaves Gerar richer than he entered — exactly as he left Egypt richer in Genesis 12:16. Twice now, the lie has paid.

THE REFORMED LENS

The eighth commandment requires “the lawful procuring and furthering the wealth and outward estate of ourselves and others,” and forbids “whatsoever doth or may unjustly hinder” the same. Hold Abraham against that. He *hindered* Abimelech’s estate — the wombs of that household were closed on account of what he set up (20:18) — and then accepted payment for damage he had caused. The gain is real; the title to it is not.

WSC 74–75 • WLC 140–142 — restitution, truth and faithfulness in contracts, and giving and lending freely are named as positive duties; fraud and oppression among what is forbidden.

HC 110–111 — God forbids not only outright theft but every scheme for getting a neighbor’s goods, and requires that I work faithfully so I can give to those in need.

This is the session that will make the room uncomfortable, and it should. The eighth commandment is not only about how money is *taken*. It is about how money is *kept*. Repentance has a ledger.

“Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have, for he has said, ‘I will never leave you nor forsake you.’”

HEBREWS 13:5

The security Abraham tried to manufacture with a lie is the security Hebrews says he already held by promise. Pair it with Hebrews 10:34, where believers *“joyfully accepted the plundering of your property, since you knew that you yourselves had a better possession and an abiding one.”*

That is the whole difference. A believer who owns a better and abiding possession can afford to lose. Abraham, in Gerar, could not afford to lose — so he took.

QUESTIONS

1. Is a person property? On what grounds does the eighth commandment apply to Genesis 20:2 at all?
2. Abimelech restores more than he took. Abraham restores nothing. What does the narrator accomplish by putting those two in the same chapter?
3. WSC 74 makes *furthering your neighbour’s* estate a positive duty of the eighth commandment. Name one concrete way you could obey that this month.
4. Is there money, standing, or advantage in your life that arrived through something you would not want examined? What does repentance actually require you to do with it?

CONFESSION AND PRAYER

Pray Hebrews 13:5 as a confession of contentment — naming one specific thing you are gripping.

IX

SESSION FOUR · THE NINTH COMMANDMENT

You shall not bear false witness

“You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor.”

EXODUS 20:16 · DEUTERONOMY 5:20

IN GERAR

“He said of Sarah his wife, ‘She is my sister’” (20:2). Then the defense, once he is caught:

“Besides, she is indeed my sister, the daughter of my father though not the daughter of my mother, and she became my wife.”

GENESIS 20:12

It is true. Every word of it is technically true. And it was engineered to produce a false belief in the hearer — which it did, all the way to a king’s household and a closed womb.

Then the worst verse in the chapter.

“And when God caused me to wander from my father’s house, I said to her, ‘This is the kindness you must do me: at every place to which we come, say of me, He is my brother.’”

GENESIS 20:13

This was not panic. It was **standing policy**. Abraham institutionalized his unbelief and called it kindness. And Abimelech — the man with no covenant, no promise, no revelation until last night — delivers the rebuke: “*You have done to me things that ought not to be done*” (20:9).

THE REFORMED LENS

The ninth commandment requires “the maintaining and promoting of truth between man and man, and of our own and our neighbour’s good name, especially in witness-bearing.” The Larger Catechism is startlingly precise here: among the sins it forbids, it names **equivocation and mental reservation** — saying something true in a sense you know your hearer will not take. That is Genesis 20:12, defined in advance by the catechism.

WSC 76–78 · WLC 143–145 — “equivocation and mental reservation” stand in the list of forbidden sins alongside outright lying.

HC 112 — I must not twist anyone’s words, must love the truth, speak it candidly, and defend my neighbor’s honor and good name.

The deeper false witness. Abraham’s premise in 20:11 — “there is no fear of God at all in this place” — was a claim about God’s reach. By how he behaved, he testified that God’s protection stopped at the border of Gerar. That was the lie underneath the lie. Every deception is finally a statement about what we believe God will and will not do.

THE HEBREWS ANCHOR

“So that by two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us. We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul.”

HEBREWS 6:18–19

Hebrews 6 is *about Abraham* — God’s oath to him is the case study (6:13–15). The chapter’s argument is that God secured the promise with an oath because he cannot lie. Set that beside a man who cannot stop lying about the very promise he carries.

Then read Hebrews 4:12–13: “*no creature is hidden from his sight, but all are naked and exposed to the eyes of him to whom we must give account.*” Genesis 20:3 is that verse in narrative form. The scheme lasted until God decided to speak, and not one minute longer.

QUESTIONS

1. Is a true statement designed to deceive a lie? Answer from WLC 145 before answering from instinct.
2. Abraham’s arrangement in 20:13 was made years in advance. What deceptions have you *systematized* rather than committed in a moment?
3. What did Abraham’s behavior testify about God to the people of Gerar? What does yours testify to the people who watch you work?
4. Why does the outsider get the moral high ground in verse 9 — and what is the narrator doing to the reader by arranging it that way?

CONFESSION AND PRAYER

Confess a specific half-truth by name, not deception in general. Read Hebrews 6:18 aloud as the counter-testimony.

You shall not covet

“You shall not covet your neighbor’s house; you shall not covet your neighbor’s wife, or his male servant, or his female servant, or his ox, or his donkey, or anything that is your neighbor’s.”

EXODUS 20:17 • DEUTERONOMY 5:21

IN GERAR

Read 20:2, 20:11 and 20:13 again — this time for *desire*, not action.

The tenth commandment names “your neighbor’s wife” out loud. Abimelech’s taking in verse 2 began before verse 2, in wanting. But the sharper reading indicts the believer: Abraham’s covetousness is for his own survival, his own comfort, his own standing — and Sarah is the instrument he is willing to spend to get it.

That is what coveting does. It converts a person into a means.

The tenth is the one commandment that cannot be kept outwardly, because it has no outward form. It proves the other nine were never merely about behavior. Paul says exactly this: “*I would not have known what it is to covet if the law had not said, ‘You shall not covet’*” (Romans 7:7).

THE REFORMED LENS

The tenth commandment requires “full contentment with our own condition, with a right and charitable frame of spirit toward our neighbour, and all that is his,” and forbids “all discontentment with our own estate, envying or grieving at the good of our neighbour, and all inordinate motions and affections to any thing that is his.”

Inordinate motions and affections. Not acts. Motions. The law reaches into the part of you that no one audits.

WSC 79–81 • WLC 146–148 — contentment commanded; envy, discontent and disordered desire forbidden.

HC 114 — Can those converted to God keep these commandments perfectly? No. Even the holiest have only a small beginning of this obedience in this life.

HC 115 — Then why does God have them preached so strictly? So that all our life long we come to know our sinful nature more and more, and so press on toward perfection, praying for the grace of the Holy Spirit.

Genesis 20 is HC 114 in narrative. Abraham is genuinely converted, and he has a small beginning of obedience — visible in 20:17, where he prays for the man he wronged. The chapter refuses both lies at once: that believers

outgrow sin, and that sin proves you were never a believer.

THE HEBREWS ANCHOR

“These all died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar... they desired a better country, that is, a heavenly one.”

HEBREWS 11:13, 16

The cure for coveting is not less desire. It is desire aimed higher. Hebrews 11:10 says Abraham “was looking forward to the city that has foundations, whose designer and builder is God.” In Gerar he was looking forward to getting out of town alive. Same man, same appetite, pointed two different directions.

QUESTIONS

1. Why does the tenth commandment need to exist if the first nine are already given?
2. Where does Abraham treat Sarah as a means rather than a person — and what desire is he serving when he does?
3. HC 114 says even the holiest have only a small beginning of obedience. How does that keep you from despair *and* from complacency at the same time?
4. Name the desire under your most persistent sin. Where would that same desire go if it were aimed at “a better country”?

CONFESSION AND PRAYER

Pray HC 115 as a request: that God would use the strictness of the law to show you yourself, and then give the Spirit to press on.

The better word

Read Genesis 20:17–18, then Genesis 21:1–2. Two things end the episode, and they should end the study.

First, Abraham prays. *“Then Abraham prayed to God, and God healed Abimelech, and also healed his wife and female slaves so that they bore children”* (20:17). The offender intercedes for the offended, at God’s own instruction — “he is a prophet, so that he will pray for you” (20:7) — and the wombs open. It is a shadow, a thin one, of something better.

“Consequently, he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them.”

HEBREWS 7:25

Abraham interceded once, for one household, having caused the damage himself. Christ intercedes always, for all who come, having caused none of it.

Second, God keeps the promise anyway. *“The LORD visited Sarah as he had said... and Sarah conceived and bore Abraham a son in his old age at the time of which God had spoken to him”* (21:1–2). The man carrying the promise nearly bartered it away in Gerar. Isaac arrives on schedule — not because Abraham finally cleared the second table, but because the promise never rested on him.

And when Hebrews 11 lists Abraham’s faith, Gerar is not in the record. Not because it did not happen, but because it was covered.

“...and to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel.”

HEBREWS 12:24

The second table accuses. Abel’s blood cried out from the ground for justice. The sprinkled blood speaks a better word over the same evidence — and it is speaking it over Genesis 20.

Close with Hebrews 12:1–2: lay aside the weight, run with endurance, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith.

At a glance

	COMMANDMENT	GENESIS 20	HEBREWS	CATECHISM
VI	Murder	3, 7, 11, 18	2:14–15 · 13:6	WSC 68–69 · WLC 135–136 · HC 105–107
VII	Adultery	2–6, 16	13:4	WSC 70–72 · WLC 137–139 · HC 108–109
VIII	Theft	2, 7, 14–16	13:5 · 10:34	WSC 73–75 · WLC 140–142 · HC 110–111
IX	False witness	2, 5, 9–13	6:18–19 · 4:12–13	WSC 76–78 · WLC 143–145 · HC 112
X	Coveting	2, 11, 13	11:13, 16 · 13:5	WSC 79–81 · WLC 146–148 · HC 113–115

Scripture quotations follow the ESV. WSC — Westminster Shorter Catechism. WLC — Westminster Larger Catechism. HC — Heidelberg Catechism. Verify every catechism citation against your own copy before teaching from it.